

ICS goodness for Galaxy phones

Samsung confirms Ice Cream Sandwich coming to Galaxy SII in early 2012

Its a ban!

HTC ushers in the new year with a ban on its smartphones in the U.S. market



Viewsonic ViewPad 7e

apps according to them.

The Viewsonic ViewPad 7e has just arrived in the Indian market. The form is based on the concept of straight lines and minimalist design. Its sparkling white body attempts to bring in a retro look, or so it seems! Four hardware buttons accompany the 7-inch display, and that works both ways—it looks good and is easier to use in the dark than touch-sensitive keys, but does seem out of place in the overall touchscreen environment. We didn't mind the overall build quality, but the performance package left a lot to be desired. The tablet's display screen isn't the best, the touch experience isn't smooth; it's as if there's a plastic protector stuck on the top. Secondly, the "3D" interface slows down the performance. And takes ages to respond itself, even if you're trying to move a widget around. When we received the tablet, it was a normal Android tablet. A couple of days later, we downloaded a 300+ MB update that reared its notification head. Post that, access to Android Market was removed, and a bunch of other apps were integrated into the ROM. If you're Amazon, this is acceptable, since there's an equally loaded app store as an alternative. In this case, nothing

of that sort really exists.

When we had reviewed the Reliance 3G Tab sometime back, we were pleasantly surprised by the overall experience it offered – decent build quality, a good touchscreen, slick UI and good battery life. However, the only catch was that it was locked to the Reliance 3G GSM network. Makes a lot of sense for someone who doesn't mind signing up for a Reliance 3G plan as well – an added monthly expenditure. From what we experienced, the speeds on offer are quite good, and the 3G Tab's battery lasted about four hours as a pretty competent Wi-Fi hotspot. Despite having the lowest benchmark figures in this price segment, the 3G Tab doesn't feel any slower than the rest of them. We've



Reliance 3G Tab

given this the **Editor's Pick** award in this category, simply because it flatters to deceive. For the better!

The only 10-inch screen tablet in this price segment is the MSi Enjoy 10. Its 10.1-inch display has a resolution of 1024x768 pixels with a 4:3 aspect ratio, which frankly just seems out of place in the

widescreen format ratios of most tablet displays. Despite a 1GHz processor and 512 MB of RAM, the boot-up time was around 1 minute and 30 sec-



MSi Enjoy 10

onds. Despite the benchmark scores indicating very good performance, the Enjoy 10 seemed a lot more sluggish in real-world usage. In the midst of very normal usage patterns, it would suddenly slow down (almost freeze) and take its own sweet time to respond. Unless you really want a 10-inch tablet that offers a USB hub as well, we suggest you check out the alternatives in this price bracket.

The winner

Despite having the same 1GHz Cortex A8 processor as most of its rivals, the Slide has by far the best benchmarking figures, and absolutely no shenanigans with performance. A minimalist UI over Android 2.3 has retained performance along with functionality. With 8 GB of built-in storage, a microSD card slot and a USB hub (compatible with data cards as well).

No real faults with the iBall Slide's build quality – even the plastic seems quite solidly put together, given its price. The 7-inch display felt better than quite a few of the rival tablets. This could just be the perfect "first" tablet experience, without too much expense! At a price of just under ₹14k, we have a real winner on our hands.

₹20,000 and above

This is the business end of the tablet market, quite literally. In the previous category, we had various flavours of Android across all tablets. But here's where the mix becomes considerably varied, with Apple's iOS and BlackBerry's Tablet OS mixing it up with Android.

First up is the BlackBerry PlayBook. Superb in many ways and

equally appalling showing in many other ways. The PlayBook does considerably well in some aspects, namely: the excellent display, good performance, unbelievably brilliant multitasking capabilities and a very sleek form factor. But, the over-reliance on paired BlackBerry phones to achieve its full potential is a turn-off for someone not using a RIM smartphone. And we've been hearing that the Android apps will be ported to the tablet, but that hasn't happened. Maybe, with the Tablet OS 2.0 update early next year, we'll get the promised integrated email and



iBall Slide